

Lost Ground

An Anthology of Heartbreak
for our Wilting Community

A Grassroots Collection

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FOREWORD

CHARLIE CAINE

December 2019 was a devastating time for many of us: the 2017 General Election had given us a glimmer of hope that we could change to a progressive society where people weren't punished for being poor and capitalists couldn't continue to abuse and exploit us; where marginalised people could feel protected under the law and immigrants and refugees could feel safe and welcome; where we could build a Green New Deal and combat the greatest threat to our continued existence. That hope came crashing down on election night when the exit polls came in. A man who called gay men "tanked topped bumboys" enjoyed burning money in front of homeless people and hid in a fridge from journalists had won over a man who said "wouldn't it be nice if we created a fairer society?"

Since that day, we have been suffering under the evil and incompetence of this government: a Government that allowed a deadly pandemic to run rife through care homes, that didn't provide proper safety equipment for health workers and that oversaw one of the worst COVID death rates in the world. So many of us muse on how different things could have been, had the people who wanted to fund the NHS properly and provide health and shelter for all won over a campaign of hate and lies.

During this time a group of us got together and decided to vent our anger and sadness through art and as such we have created this artistic response to the General Election result of 2019. We still hope for a better future and believe that one day we will create it. Until that time we stand in solidarity with all who are suffering because of the actions and inactions of this monstrous Government.

A BRIDGE, A CASTLE, AND SOME LEAFLETS

MOLLY POTTER

Once upon a time there was a small island just off the north-west coast of a giant mainland. It was a feistily independent island and often liked to do things its own way, but after years of quibbling between the islanders and the mainlanders, the island was eventually attached to the considerably larger mainland by a strong, practical steel bridge. This seemed to stop a lot of the squabbling and the people of the island and mainland started working well together and crossing the bridge both ways quite happily. The bridge seemed to improve the relationships between the mainland and the island. Many people on the island started to think of themselves as part of the mainland and many friendships blossomed regardless of which side of the bridge people originally came from.

On the island, right next to a river, there was a vast castle with defences few would even attempt to penetrate. Those few who were admitted did so via an attitude test and a large financial donation which funded campaigns that told everyone how great they were and how they deserved to live in the castle. The people of the castle were very greedy and needed quite a lot of money to maintain their lifestyle. They also liked power. The people of the castle made all the decisions about how the masses outside could and could not live on the island. As time went on, the people of the castle made their walls thicker and higher so that fewer and fewer people could see what was going on inside.

The people that lived inside the castle, maintained lives of privilege and luxury. Although they would never admit it, they were a bit scared of the masses who lived outside the walls, as they made up such large numbers. Because of this fear, right next to the castle, attached by a corridor, there was a noisy leaflet factory. This factory was well-funded by the people of the castle as its job was to produce many leaflets that sent crafty messages that stopped the masses ever considering attacking the castle. The leaflet delivered simple messages like, 'Watch your neighbour, he might steal from you', 'we need to be careful with money, there really isn't much' or 'look at the bridge, all the people coming across it.' This successfully occupied many of the masses with feelings of hatred for their neighbours. While the masses were busy pointing fingers at each other, they forgot to even consider the castle and what might be going on behind its thick walls.

On the opposite side of the castle from the leaflet factory, there was a small village. The castle allowed them to exist as representatives who kept them informed about what the masses might want. They didn't really listen well to the people of the village and only let them speak through a tiny hatch in the castle wall. The people in this village really cared about the masses and tried their best for them but they lacked the power of the castle.

At one point an argument broke out inside the castle. Even though the bridge worked really well and people and goods travelled both ways across it, questions were being asked about whether it was really a good thing or not. Some even suggested it should be blown up, even though some of the country's poorest people lived on the cliffs nearby and the explosion was sure to make the villages atop them crumble into the sea. Such unrest was caused by the debate about the bridge that the people of the castle impulsively and somewhat uncharacteristically decided to ask the masses what they thought. The masses said, but not overly loudly, 'we don't want the bridge anymore.'

The following few years saw the residents of the castle being ignored and they continued to live comfortably behind the castle walls while the masses started turning on each other. All effective debate stopped and the masses simply started shouting at each other—and not just about the bridge. They shouted about people coming across the bridge, they shouted about those that had already crossed it, they shouted about doctors' appointments, schools and hospitals, but people were only listening to those shouting the same things as themselves. The leaflets continued to be sent but their messages needed to become simpler because people had become so poor at listening, for example, 'No bridge means no bridge'. The village next to the castle, along with some of the masses, piped up and made some of their own leaflets, but they didn't have a giant leaflet factory like those in the castle had built and their messages were not heard as much. A few experts spoke up, but they had even less chance of being listened to with all the shouting going on and emotions running so unrestrainedly.

After a considerable amount of time, still nothing had been decided or sorted about the fate of the bridge, although by now the most powerful people had decided they really did not want it. People in the castle had started to realise that the bridge meant the mainland could keep an eye on them. This sometimes stopped the castle's occupants from doing just what they liked.

The people in the castle were also still agitated. It was proving to be neither straightforward nor easy to get rid of the bridge as it had been built in such a complicated way. There was still so much confusion about the bridge that the people of the castle decided to let

the masses decide whether they should stay in the castle and sort out the bridge or let the people of the village move in and do it instead. 'Pah,' said the masses, 'the people of the village won't sort anything, they are too weak and they will spend too much money'. So the people of the castle were allowed to stay there. Of course, people were just reading these words off the latest leaflets.

And so with boosted confidence that had now become arrogance (because the masses had let them stay), the people of the castle continued to make decisions about the masses' lives. Their new confidence meant they didn't need to worry as much as they had believed about what the masses thought, as the leaflets appeared to work extremely well. The fact that nobody was listening to anyone also seemed to help. The people of the castle maintained their greed and comfortable life by slowly reducing the amount of money that was to be spent on the masses so they could keep it for themselves. And as for the bridge, that got quietly dismantled one night when the leaflets sent out a story about a nasty virus on the other side of the world.

BIG BEN BONG

AMANDA COLEMAN

On the Big Ben bong,
When the clock went wrong
And the government all went BOO!
There's a bong, big, ben
Where grown up men
Snort coke and jibber, jabber, joo.
On the ben, bong, big
They've been known to fuck a pig
And you just can't believe it when they do!
So it's big ben bong.
Clock went wrong.
Bong, big, ben.
Rich white men.
Ben, bong, big.
Boris in a wig.
What a crazy place to belong.
When asked to bung a bob for a Big Ben bong!

CRIME

TONY WARNER

‘Come back here, you little bugger! I’ll have the police on you. Don’t you dare show your face round here again!’ The shopkeeper waved his arms in impotent fury. The child disappeared rapidly round the corner of the street, his gains clutched tightly in one hand. No point in giving chase: age, a large belly and a sedentary lifestyle prohibited any violent exercise.

‘May I help you, sir?’ A police support officer and a uniformed constable.

‘Looks like she’s just out of school,’ thought the shopkeeper. ‘Yeah, caught that little bugger rifling the till while I was busy filling the shelves. Took a whole load of fifty pence pieces. Good job I’d just emptied out the notes for the day to take to the bank. Typical Mile Cross brat. Dragged up in the gutter. No respect for no-one.’

‘I’ll radio it in, sir. If you could just give me a description.’

‘No need for that,’ an elderly woman volunteered, flushed and excited under a mask of face powder. ‘I know who it is. Round the corner, first left. Number seventeen. A whole mob of ’em, dirty little rascals. And she’s no better than she should be.’

‘Thank you madam. If you would leave your name and address my colleague and I will interview you formally later.’

Number seventeen was no worse than the rest of the street, muddy front garden where a car had once been parked, now overgrown with weeds, broken upstairs window patched with cardboard. The door was ajar as if it had been thrown closed in a hurry. The constable knocked, walked in to the bare hallway. As he did so the lights suddenly came on. A long cupboard behind the kitchen was open. Inside a lad of ten or eleven in faded jeans and a dirty T-shirt some sizes too small for him was busy feeding fifty pence pieces into the electricity meter.

‘Are you on your own?’ asked the support officer. ‘Come with me and sit down.’ The living room was bare except for a rickety metal table and a huge battered sofa, its Salvation Army label still attached. Two girls sat playing with rag dolls while a younger child in a filthy nappy stood howling in the corner. The boy and the officers sat together on the sofa. ‘Shouldn’t you be in school?’

‘Excluded.’

‘Where’s your mother?’ the woman asked.

‘Dunno. Me mam said we had no money so she went off in her best gear to get some. She always does that when we run out of money. Comes back late. Then the lights went out and the girls were frightened.’

‘So you robbed the shop of fifty pence pieces to get some money for the meter?’

‘Yeah.’

‘When was this? When did your mam go?’

‘Two nights ago, maybe three.’

The constable reached for his radio. ‘Call social services to this address. And CID. Let’s pray we are not looking for a body.’

THE FARMER'S WOE

ANDREW K COPEMAN

Like lambs to the slaughter
Chained together at our necks
The farmer comes to us
Shouting "get it done!"

Struggle to break our bonds
And tear through misery
As our flock starves in line
Through our morals' steep decline

And the madness starts to drive
Whipping our skin apart
The people's red starts to flow
As some fight our place in line

Hold your fear and scream with me
Until his ears start to bleed
Floods of blue run down his throat
Coughing up garbled noise

In this place we still fight on
And break out from our bonds
The lambs, we start to grow
Horns to gouge out our few rights

Like rams charging in the night
We fight to earn our rights
The farmer yields to us
But whispers: "It's already done."

FLIGHTLESS BIRDS

ASPEN PERRY

“Hello,” she says, “big issue?” She’s the fifth homeless person I’ve seen since I arrived in town, twenty minutes ago, but the only one lucky enough to be selling anything.

“I’m sorry, I haven’t got any money.”

“Any money, for coff.” I pause in the street, baffled.

“For cough?”

“Coff, for coffee. It is cold.” I know, I can feel the biting wind tear through my clothes. I reach into my pocket, and pull out a few ten pence pieces, placing them into her waiting hand. She doesn’t look impressed. A tiny trill rings through the air as a fledgling peaks its head over the nest, to spy on us.

“I’m sorry, it’s all I have.” How painfully true, I have nothing. No change, no notes, just enough in the bank to cover my credit card bill, if I’m lucky. All those people I pass, I only wish I had enough money to make their lives a little easier. It hurts to see another person suffer, alone in the cold. Self loathing sometimes rises in my chest because I should be more generous with money I don’t have, and more empathetic to people I don’t know, but I just don’t have enough to go round.

Our government should be the ones to protect us from these dangers, why else would they take our money so unrepentantly? Where is our protection? I worry at night that it’ll be me on the street one day, freezing and vulnerable, because it’s impossible to get by these days. I hope for a brighter future, for a gust of wind beneath my wings.

She smiles. “God bless!” I smile back, sick to my stomach. God bless the man that gives when he has nothing. Where were the blessings when prejudice, greed, and corruption poisoned our country?

The only gods I know are vengeful and hateful, racist and sexist, transphobic and homophobic. They have the power to save or condemn, to help or hinder. Their actions go unpunished, their power is absolute.

And so, like birds in the nest, we have been shunted from our safety, falling ever faster to the hard and unforgiving ground, where a sleeping bag awaits us all.

THE HUMAN NATURE

VANESSA ATALANTA

A crow pecks the eyes out
of a sheep whose head is caught in a wire mesh fence.
A fox bites into a housecat's tender nape,
breaking its neck.
A spider injects paralytic venom into a moth
before encasing it in webbing and eating it alive.

When did we become so cruel?
At least spiders don't force their prey
to break down crying on the food bank floor.
At least crows look their victims in the eye.

Is this the Human Nature?
What sick, toxic gene pool did it crawl out of?
If—Heaven forbid—the Human were manufactured
it would have to be outlawed and annihilated at once
as a crime against nature.

And what a heartless joke
that the doe, the rabbit, the trembling field mouse
must walk down the high street,
go within striking distance of the Human,
and ask it for A Young Person's Day Ticket, Please.

ONE DAY IN A LIFE

ANDREW K COPEMAN

He brushed the lapels of his old blue suit, sprayed with last Christmas's Lynx Africa to drown out the musty smell clinging to the fibres, a blue sticker struggled to cling on. He tried and failed to flatten the curling white letters that proudly shouted: 'I voted'. The winter sky was clear that morning, and the breeze piercing with cold, as Dave made his way through trudging crowds of downcast faces towards the Tesco express, snatching a six pack with glee. *What a day to celebrate!* He approached the checkout clerk with suspicion, however, when he saw her short hair shaved at one side and rings throughout her ears. *Fucking millennial.*

"Hello," she said.

"Ain't you supposed to say: 'good morning, sir'?" She stared, blankly. He watched as she took one deep breath.

"I'm sorry. Are you having a good morning?"

"I am, matter o' fact. Time to finally clean this country up innit?" *She looks like she's gonna be sick.* Dave smiled. He'd won, that was all that mattered.

He stuffed his purchases into his bag and crammed the receipt into his pocket before striding out into the street. He felt invincible. *Boris will get it done.*

"Spare change, sir?" Dave looked down at the man wrapped tightly in a sleeping bag, his arms hugging a battered guitar. A smell wafted around him, thick in his nostrils; the smell of the homeless.

"What, so you can spend it on more booze? Get lost."

"Mate, if I had enough for booze I'd have already drunk meself to death." Dave rolled his eyes.

"Am I supposed to feel sorry for you?"

"Ugh." The noise drew his attention: a woman stood ahead of him, long greying hair flowing over her shoulders. She was staring at him.

"What are you looking at?" her husband bristled and he felt a rush of pleasure and power course through his skin as he squared his shoulders. The woman matched his stance, however.

"Scum," she sneered.

"How fucking dare you!" he shouted, but she didn't seem fazed at all. She just stared him straight in the eye. The blood began to rush through his ears, and rage squeezed around his throat, his breathing

coming shorter and sharper. Her husband pulled out a phone, to call 999 no doubt. "Socialist loser," he spat, before he walked away.

That's right, she's just a sore fucking loser, a special snowflake. Boris will get it done.

He turned back for just a moment, to make sure they weren't calling the rozzers, and saw her hand a purple note to the lazy twat on the street.

"It's all I've got, I'm sorry." *Sorry! For being scammed!* Dave couldn't help but chuckle. *What an idiot!* He almost felt like skipping through the streets. With a smile he took a seat in the park, watching as heavy clouds began to roll across the sky. He tore the plastic from a magazine, shoving it into the nearby bin already overflowing with rubbish. *Fucking council need to empty these more often.* The plastic fell back out, tumbling along the pavement and past his seat. *Shameful*, he thought, *that they let crap flow through the streets like this.* It drew his eyes to a group of kids sat around a tree stump, skins a thousand different colours. They looked lazy, hugging their knees and cuddling each other, *in the middle of the fucking day!*

Two boys on bikes sped by, navy hoods pulled over their hats. "Paki cunts!" one shouted at the kids. Although the boys were already gone their words lingered as a girl began to cry. *Ha! Freeloading foreigners; Boris will sort it.*

The crisp air began to seep through his clothes and settle into his bones. *Even colder than I thought today.* It was almost Christmas and while all the decorations were up in the streets and the shops, there was none of the festive cheer; no carollers or nut vendors, no smiles or laughter, but every now and then he'd see someone just like him; a proudly suited chest thrust forward with confidence. *Winners.*

Dave followed the winding streets to the bus station, each step heavier than the last. The shelter's thin, tilting seats made a fire climb his back, higher and higher the longer he sat. *Sodding bus should have been here twenty minutes ago!* In the dying light he struggled to read the sign, squinting harder and harder. *An hour? I have to wait another bloody hour! I remember now, they reduced the buses. Those wankers!* He took a single, heaving, sigh.

Boris will sort it all.

THE VOICES OF IGNORANCE

ANDREW K COPEMAN

Homophobia is loud!
Shouting on buses,
Violent and proud.
It's in the news
"It's just another's views"
It threatens and demeans
It strangles and screams
Behind and in front of the scenes
It rages and rips
From between snarling lips
And tries to crush our morale
With ignorant rationale.

And yet we will fight on
Against your rising con.

UNFORTUNATE

ASPEN PERRY

The world is filled with unfortunate mistakes
Such easy things we make
Dead certainty becomes thriving instability
And a raging liability
It can be difficult to accept
So resentment is kept
The future seems clouded by pain
And peace hard to obtain
While the way is concealed by the storm
Maybe it guides us to reform

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